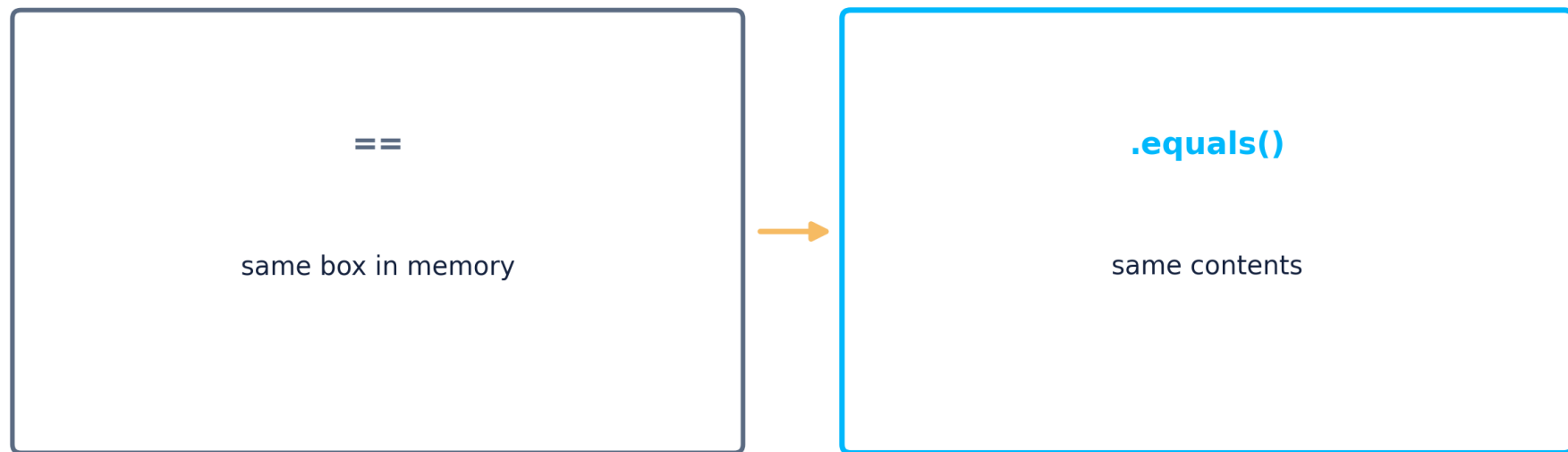


== compares boxes, .equals compares contents



Same box, or same contents?

Two Strings that look identical can still be **not equal** in Java. Here is why.

- 1 `==` asks: are these the **same object in memory**?
- 2 `.equals()` asks: do they **hold the same value**?
- 3 Small strings get reused by the JVM, so `==` sometimes works — by accident.

REMEMBER

Use `.equals()` for values. The times `==` works are luck, not logic.

